

Title MD A Russian Influence Operation Targets Moldovan Christians Ahead of Elections 8/10/2025

Summary

- A Kremlin-linked influence operation in Moldova, codenamed Matushka, was using religious narratives and Orthodox Church networks to sway voters ahead of the 2025 parliamentary elections. Disguised as religious outreach, this operation spread anti-EU, anti-government messaging across social media platforms, mobilising Christians - especially youth - through coordinated content, online petitions, and offline activities tied to pro-Russian political goals.
- The key narrative pushed by the Matushka operation was that European integration threatens Moldova's Christian values, national identity, and the Orthodox Church, while the pro-Western government is portrayed as hostile to Orthodox faith.
- The operation has built a coordinated network of 67 channels across seven platforms to mobilise Moldovan Orthodox Christians, especially youth, against pro-EU parties ahead of the 2025 elections.
- The operation leverages deceptive identities, manipulated content, amplification, discrediting, polarisation, and fabrication to covertly influence Moldova's 2025 elections by weaponising religious networks and narratives.
- To counter the operation, authorities and civil society should disrupt the disinformation network across platforms, expose its Russian ties, and promote counter-narratives that align Orthodox values with democracy and European integration.

Incident

Between 2024 and 2025, Russian-affiliated actors launched a covert influence operation in Moldova, codenamed Matushka, to sway public opinion ahead of the country's September 2025 parliamentary elections. Operated through Kremlin-linked networks, the campaign used Moldovan clergy, youth activists, and a coordinated social media ecosystem centered on the Salt and Light (Sare și Lumină) social media brand. This network spanned 67 channels across Telegram, TikTok, Facebook, YouTube, and Instagram, disguised as Orthodox religious content but actively [disseminating anti-EU](#), [anti-government](#) narratives. One key moment occurred during a March 2025 pilgrimage to Bethlehem, where a Kremlin strategist [instructed](#) priests to build parish-based youth cells to oppose European integration, with the promise of financial and logistical support.

The campaign targeted Moldovan Orthodox Christians using familiar religious imagery and emotionally charged messaging to portray the pro-European government, especially the ruling [PAS party](#) in Moldova and President Maia Sandu, as threats to [traditional values](#) and national identity. Through viral [visuals](#), [polls](#), [petitions](#), and coordinated posts, the operation claimed that EU integration would bring moral decay and suppress the Church. Its goal was to mobilise voters to oppose pro-Western candidates and back Kremlin-aligned figures. By embedding political propaganda in religious discourse, Matushka aimed to manipulate faith communities into acting as a loyal electoral base against pro-Western parties.

Systemic Violation Assessment

This incident represents a serious risk because it manipulates religious beliefs to spread disinformation, polarise society, and mobilise voters under false pretences. By disguising political messaging as religious content, it undermines informed decision-making and distorts the democratic process - potentially influencing election outcomes.

This incident is a clear case of information manipulation because it disguises political propaganda as religious content. The manipulation lies in using trusted Church platforms and figures to spread false narratives, while hiding the operation's Kremlin ties, thus misleading the public and distorting political debate.

This type of manipulation could potentially be illegal in Moldova. It may violate laws related to foreign interference in elections, unauthorised political campaigning by religious institutions, and the use of disinformation to influence voters. Moldova's legal framework prohibits religious entities from engaging in electoral propaganda, and foreign-funded influence operations could also breach national security or media transparency laws.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Orthodox Christianity is under attack by pro-European forces, and only a return to traditional, pro-Russian values can protect Moldova's faith, identity, and sovereignty.

Sub-narratives: European integration equals moral decay – portrayed through visuals contrasting Orthodox values with Western liberalism; The Church is being persecuted – suggesting that the Moldovan government is suppressing religious freedoms; Moldova is being "sold out" to the West– implying a loss of sovereignty and cultural erasure; Voting is a religious duty – urging Christians to support pro-Russian candidates to defend faith and tradition.

Impact

Reach: The operation reached tens of thousands of users across multiple social media platforms. On Telegram, it operated 25 channels with nearly 12,000 subscribers, while on TikTok, 22 channels had over 21,000 followers. Its Instagram network included 11 accounts with more than 3,700 followers. The Salt and Light YouTube channel had 2,750 subscribers and over one million views, while the youth-focused KovchegMD channel had nearly 1,000 subscribers and more than 160,000 views. Additionally, the Salt and Light Facebook group had just over 900 members.

Outcome: N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [T0135.001: Smear](#): discrediting Moldova's leadership and political institutions

Objective: [T0135.004: Polarise](#): divide target audience by antagonising them against the government.

[T0097.101: Local Persona](#): at least one Russian admin of Facebook group used a fake persona to pretend he was from Moldova.

[T0094.001: Identify Susceptible Targets in Networks](#): infiltrating into religious community and targeting young people in Moldova.

[T0122: Direct Users to Alternative Platforms](#): Facebook posts of the network directed users to Telegram to play quiz games.

[T0119.002: Post across Platform](#): this operation was conducted on multiple platforms and similar or identical content was used on several platforms.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: public exposure and documentation of the operation.

Recommendations: Disruption of the infrastructure by social media platforms and service providers; Deployment of strategic counter-narratives by CSOs and Moldovan government to keep Moldovan religious community informed about information threats; Secure the electoral process.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
Link	Russia.	Upon Request	Victoria Olari, DFRLab Sopo Gelava, DFRLab Givi Gigitashvili, DFRLab	Facebook, YouTube, TikTok, Telegram	High certainty